especially for daily wage workers and household help, who was then advised to stop creating a 'drama', and just use Paytm.[24]

In the meanwhile, the company claimed that it registered a 700 per cent increase in overall traffic and 1,000 per cent growth in the amount of money added to the Paytm account. During this period, the transaction value continued to be 200 per cent of the average ticket size while the number of app downloads went up 300 per cent. The number of transactions per user also went up from three transactions to over 18 transactions in a week.[25]

It was clear that Paytm was one of the biggest beneficiaries of demonetization. In an article by Bloomberg[26] on 10 January 2017, founder Sharma was quoted as saying that post-demonetization Paytm had been signing up the equivalent of a small European country's quantum of customers every week. 'Overnight,' Sharma says, 'we went from a new thing to a must-have… I want to be India's first $100 billion company by value… I think I've landed in the world where there are miracles at work.'

While the Paytm miracle unfolded, arguments on the benefits of a cashless India trotted out by various government officials and spokespersons showed how muddled their thoughts were on this matter.

The first argument was that less cash in the economy would reduce corruption, based on the mistaken premise that it was cash that caused corruption. The second argument was that if every transaction were to be digitally recorded, tax evasion would be reduced. The third was that the economy would become more advanced and efficient with less cash used, as many developed economies have a lower cash to GDP ratio. All of these confused cause and effect and, moreover, targeted cash as the enemy.

Nevertheless, no matter what the arguments, let us assess whether demonetization was successful in achieving its objective of making India use 'less cash'. While there is no doubt that the use of e-wallets like Paytm skyrocketed, and more and more Indians started using